

REGAL REVIVAL

Havelis and forts are set to come alive with cultural shows and events, which will attract more tourists and make them self-sustaining

■ By Rohit Parihar

The best of buildings, laid with the choicest of construction material, erected on prime real estate—it was all there, but mere marble and sandstone for tourists. The singularity and the magnificence of these structures added up to nothing worthwhile for the government which owned them. But today these relics of the past are living history for the Rajasthan Government and are set to undergo a massive makeover. The state Government is trying to put the fun back into forts and hungama into old havelis. No longer will visitors have to keep track of time and make a dash for a ticket at a decrepit window before it downs shutters at five, surreptitiously look for a loo in some shady corner or struggle with a tap to quench their thirst. Taking a cue from privately-owned forts like the Mehrangarh Fort in Jodhpur, City Palace in Jaipur and heritage hotels like the Lake Palace Hotel in Udaipur, the Government has

MONUMENTAL CHANGE: Sheesh Mahal is being spruced up with new mirrors

lined up over half a dozen projects for the revival of old monuments, beginning with the 15th century Amer Fort on the outskirts of the Pink City.

Come winter and the Fort will enter a new era of nightlife with Amitabh Bachchan narrating its Gulzar-

scripted history in a light and sound programme accompanied by folk dances, fashion shows and fine dining. There will be day-long excursions with vacant corridors and rooms being converted into art galleries, cyber cafés and meena bazaar and servants' quar-

FACELIFT

Amer Fort has undergone extensive changes to accommodate recreational facilities

